moving bus in the heart of the national capital. Crimes against women are not unusual in Delhi. In fact, the city has acquired notoriety as a place where women are highly unsafe. Yet, the sheer gruesomeness of the rape appeared to shake the city from its stupor. The fact that it happened in close proximity to the headquarters of most national television channels gave it an instant profile as the big breaking news story of the moment. Silence was no longer an option. Rape could no longer be just a statistic.

Three days after the rape, as the girl battled bravely for her life in a hospital (she would die of her injuries thirteen days later), the anger spilled out onto the streets. A frenzied crowd, mainly youngsters, began marching along Rajpath towards Rashtrapati Bhavan demanding answers. Some of them even tried to climb the walls of North Block. A rattled police force used tear gas and water cannons to disperse the agitators. The crowds only grew. Gender justice campaigner Eve Ensler, on a visit to India for her One Billion Rising campaign, said she felt India was in the midst of a women's revolution.

I was at India Gate where hundreds of men and women, mainly college students, had assembled. The protests were peaceful. The demand was for justice, tougher laws and security for women. While interviewing people on the spot, someone in the gathering spoke out. 'Where is Rahul Gandhi, why doesn't he come here and talk to us? If he can go and meet farmers in Bhatta Parsaul, can he not come and meet us also?'

It appeared a perfectly legitimate question. After all, Rahul Gandhi had been projected by his party as a youth icon. He was meant to represent a generational shift in Indian politics. He himself had spoken out about the need to energize the youth and encourage new voices in public life. Here was an ideal opening for him to walk the talk—to embrace a spontaneous, public spirited movement for gender justice that was driven by a younger, impatient India hankering for change. But Rahul was nowhere to be found.

Congress spokespersons initially claimed that Rahul was out of the country when the story first surfaced. When he returned, he did meet a handful of agitators at 10, Janpath, but away from the glare of the camera. Apparently, a section of the party was keen that Rahul engage in a more